

Expert Session Summary

Session conducted by M. Saifuneesa

MANO 2026 – Kerala's First Psychology Students' Conclave

Quick Brief Summary

M. Saifuneesa talks about the career opportunities and potential of community psychology beyond clinical settings. The lecture highlights the need to prioritize the collective upliftment of society and the prevention of mental health issues over individual counseling, and emphasizes the importance of participating in such activities from student days.

Detailed Summary

Introduction

This lecture discusses the possibilities and career opportunities of community psychology beyond clinical settings. The session is led by M. Saifuneesa, an RCI-licensed rehabilitation counselor, consultant psychologist, and co-founder of Terra Wellbeing. The speaker begins the talk with a short warm-up exercise, asking members of the audience to face each other with a smile. She argues that this helps foster happiness and human connection, and that community psychology does precisely the same thing.

Main Theme: Community Psychology: Career Opportunities Beyond Clinical Boundaries

Unlike traditional clinical settings, community psychology helps address a larger society, identifying and solving the social and environmental causes of individuals' mental health issues. Beyond individual counseling, the primary goal of community psychology is to empower society through awareness, prevention, and collective action.

Key Areas Explored

Definition and Scope of Community

Communities are formed based on geographical regions, cultures, perspectives, and goals. However, in the modern world, the scope of community extends very broadly to include WhatsApp groups, social media communities, political parties, tribal groups, coastal residents, students, and women. The speaker explains how the principles and interventions of psychology can be extended to such diverse societies.

Prevention, Promotion, and Action Research

While clinical settings deal with isolated patients, the community approach addresses a large section of the population. The primary goals here are preventing mental health issues (prevention), cultivating good mental health habits (promotion), and community self-sufficiency (empowerment). To achieve this, interventions must be carried out by identifying the real needs of society using research methods such as Action Research. The speaker illustrates with examples how such models can be successfully implemented in schools, tribal areas, and transgender communities.

Community-Level Challenges and Benefits

Working at the community level often involves facing multiple challenges simultaneously. These include limited physical infrastructure, cultural diversity, a lack of permanent seating, journeys through difficult mountainous terrain, and the need for multi-tasking. Nevertheless, the mental satisfaction of bringing light to a large population, a strong networking system, and opportunities to work on funded projects make community psychology an excellent career option.

Career Opportunities and Personal Experiences

There are numerous opportunities for community psychologists in defense and security sectors like the BSF, government public sector projects, school counselor positions like Jeevani, and NGOs. However, the reality is that we are largely unaware of them. The speaker discusses initiatives she started during her student days, such as 'Justice for #Tag' (a collective against POCSO and violence against women and children) and 'Isolation Thoughts' (an online initiative started during COVID-19 for the mental well-being of children and parents). She reminds students that the student period is the most suitable time to experiment with such things.

Key Insights: Key Lessons in Community Psychology

Social Intervention: Community psychology works not just for individuals, but for the mental health and collective action of a larger society.

Real-time Action: Step out into society through NGOs and outreach programs during your student days itself, without waiting to finish your education.

Awareness and Prevention: Prevent problems beforehand through awareness and mental health promotion, rather than treating illnesses after they occur.

Networking: Community work helps develop strong social relationships and a professional network.

Conclusion: Summary and Call to Action

The lecture concludes by emphasizing that community psychology provides immense personal satisfaction. Passion and the willingness to initiate are the primary qualifications one needs. The speaker ends her talk with the reminder that every individual has a role to play in building a mentally healthy society. Following this, she invites Mr. Muhammed Ziyad to the stage for the next session's presentation on the topic 'Love'.

Highlights

Prevention, Promotion, and Empowerment

The main goals of community psychology are disease prevention, promotion of mental health awareness, and empowerment of the community. This can be implemented through awareness camps and training.

Opportunities for Students and Professionals

During their study period itself, students can work as volunteers in community projects and NGOs. There are numerous opportunities in BSF, school counselor posts (Jeevana project), and government projects.

Challenges and Great Fulfillment

Despite challenges such as limited resources, cultural diversity, and lack of a permanent space, the mental satisfaction and experiences gained when bringing about changes at the community level are immense. Saifuneesa Psychologist